8.17.3 Basic Alterations

Altering the Length

If the garment is too short or too long can able to lengthen or shorten the pattern before cutting the fabric. Usually one can make the alterations on the horizontal dashed lines marked on the patterns, such as elbow line, waistline or a hip line. On sleeves one can alter the length on the elbow line, on dresses on the waist and hip line and on trousers and skirts on the knee line.

Shortening a Pattern

- Measure the length of the pattern and take the same measurement on your body
- Compare the pattern measurements with individual measurements and calculate the difference
- Draw a horizontal line on the pattern at the level where it needed to be shortened (for example waist, hip, knee etc)
- Draw a parallel line just above periodically drawn line
- Cut the pattern into two parts from the lower line. Move and tape the lower piece straight up on the level of the upper line. Make sure that the centre front/back remains straight
- Draw the sides of the pattern smooth and continuous
- Check that seams that will be sewn together still have the same length

If the pattern gets shortened a lot, it is good to divide the difference into more than one line, for example on the waist and hip or hip and knee, in order to keep the proportions correct. It can be also measure the actual length from waist to hip so that it is easy to calculate the length to be reduced

Lengthening a Pattern

- Measure the length of the pattern and take the same measurement of the body
- Compare the pattern measurements with individual body measurements and calculate the difference
- Draw a horizontal line on the pattern at the level where it has to be lengthened (for example waist, hip, knee etc)
- Cut the pattern into two parts through the lengthening line. Place a piece of paper under the pieces and tape the lower part on it
- Draw a parallel line on the paper, the required amount above the edge of the pattern
- Tape the edge of upper pattern piece on the line. Make sure that the center front/back remains straight
- Draw the sides of the pattern smooth and continuous
- Check that the seams that will be sewn together still have the same length.

Altering the Width of a Pattern

- Altering the Width of a Pattern from Seam
- Measure the length of the pattern and take the same measurement of the body
- Compare the pattern measurements body measurements and calculate the difference. If the difference is significant width can be reduced or added from or to the waist darts, depending on the garment.

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